

Drill #1 – Inside/Outside Touches

Category: Ball Mastery

Focus: Close control, foot speed, coordination, confidence on the ball

Level: High School Varsity

Age Group: U14–Varsity

Players: 1–20+ players

Duration: 8–12 minutes

Field Size: 10x10 to 15x15 yard grid

Intensity: Moderate → High

Purpose

The **Inside/Outside Touches** drill develops a player's ability to manipulate the ball quickly and confidently while moving. Players learn to keep the ball close, change direction, and accelerate into space.

At the varsity level, this drill is not just about ball control. It teaches players to:

- Receive and move the ball quickly
- Maintain possession under pressure
- Improve weaker-foot ability
- Develop faster foot speed
- Prepare the ball for the next action

A player's first touch often determines the outcome of the next play. This drill builds the habit of keeping the ball under control while still moving at game speed.

Equipment

- One soccer ball per player
 - Cones to mark grids
 - Pinnies (optional)
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Setup

Create a square grid.

Recommended Sizes

Level	Grid Size
Beginner	15x15 yards
Intermediate	12x12 yards
Varsity	10x10 yards

Each player has a ball and begins inside the grid.

Example:

15 yards

X X X

X  X

X X X

15 yards

Players move freely throughout the grid while maintaining control of their ball.

Instructions

Players perform a series of touches while moving throughout the grid.

Phase 1 – Right Foot Inside Touches

Players use only the inside of the right foot.

Coaching emphasis:

- Push the ball slightly forward
- Keep the ball within playing distance
- Move continuously

Duration:

30 seconds

Phase 2 – Right Foot Outside Touches

Players now use only the outside of the right foot.

Emphasis:

- Keep the ball close
- Use the outside of the foot to change direction
- Protect the ball from imaginary defenders

Duration:

30 seconds

Phase 3 – Left Foot Inside Touches

Repeat using only the left foot.

Duration:

30 seconds

Phase 4 – Left Foot Outside Touches

Repeat using the outside of the left foot.

Duration:

30 seconds

Phase 5 – Alternating Inside/Outside

Players alternate:

Right inside → right outside → left inside → left outside

Example:

Inside → Outside → Inside → Outside

R R L L

Duration:

1–2 minutes

Progression 1 – Add Speed

Players increase their pace while maintaining control.

Coach command:

"Can you go faster without losing the ball?"

The goal is not maximum speed. The goal is **maximum speed with control**.

Progression 2 – Add Changes of Direction

Coach calls:

- "Turn!"
- "Change!"
- "Reverse!"

Players immediately change direction using their inside/outside touches.

Examples:

- Inside cut
- Outside cut
- Drag back
- Cruyff turn

Progression 3 – Add Pressure

Add 2–3 defenders without balls.

Defenders attempt to knock balls outside the grid.

Players must:

- Protect their ball
- Change direction
- Accelerate away from pressure

Coaching Points

1. Small Touches

The ball should never be more than one or two steps away.

Good:

Player → 

1 step

Poor:

Player → 

5 yards away

2. Use the Correct Part of the Foot

Inside touch:

- Use the middle of the inside surface
- Ankle locked
- Body over the ball

Outside touch:

- Use the outside edge of the foot

- Keep ankle firm
 - Push into space
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3. Stay Balanced

Players should:

- Bend knees
 - Stay on toes
 - Keep center of gravity low
 - Be ready to change direction
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4. Keep Head Up

Elite players do not stare at the ball.

Teach:

"Look down to touch. Look up to play."

Players should scan every few touches.

5. Accelerate After Touch

A common mistake is touching the ball but not moving.

The touch should create movement.

Example:

Touch → accelerate → scan → next touch

Common Mistakes

Mistake 1: Ball Too Far Away

Problem:

Player loses control.

Correction:

Reduce the power of the touch.

Mistake 2: Only Using Strong Foot**Problem:**

Player avoids weaker foot.

Correction:

Force weaker foot rounds.

Mistake 3: Looking Down Constantly**Problem:**

Player cannot see defenders.

Correction:

Require players to scan between touches.

Mistake 4: Standing Upright**Problem:**

Slow reaction time.

Correction:

Lower body position.

Coaching Questions

Ask players:

- "Can you keep the ball close enough to protect it?"
- "Where is the open space?"
- "Can you see before your next touch?"
- "Which foot should you use to escape pressure?"
- "Can you change direction without stopping?"

Varsity-Level Challenge

For advanced players:

The 3-Second Rule

Every 3 seconds players must:

- Change direction
- Change speed
- Change foot

This forces players to think and react like they would in a match.

Game Application

This drill directly transfers to:

- Beating defenders 1v1
- Receiving under pressure
- Maintaining possession
- Escaping tight spaces
- Creating attacking opportunities

Examples:

- A midfielder receiving with a defender closing
 - A winger attacking a fullback
 - A forward protecting the ball with back to goal
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Suggested Drill Timeline

Time Activity

2 min Free dribbling warm-up

Time Activity

2 min Inside/outside right foot

2 min Inside/outside left foot

3 min Speed and direction changes

3 min Add defenders

Key Coaching Phrase

"Touch, look, move."

Skills Developed

- ✓ Ball control
 - ✓ First touch
 - ✓ Dribbling technique
 - ✓ Agility
 - ✓ Balance
 - ✓ Weak foot development
 - ✓ Spatial awareness
 - ✓ Confidence under pressure
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- related drills (#2 Sole Rolls, #3 Cone Weave, #7 Receiving Across Body)